

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

▲ **MAYE MUSK**
Model, Dietitian, Author

LONGEVITY: Life Begins at 40 (or 70!): Ageless Ambition with Maye Musk!

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Independence builds confidence, especially in children, who must be encouraged to experiment and learn from mistakes**
- **Life can be reinvented anytime. Being open to change allows opportunities to emerge**

Doing what you love, something that is challenging and surprising, will keep you going. You'll always wake up in the morning excited

Some people are mean and you can't change them. They will be horrible no matter how polite you are. Take them out of your life

HOW TO RAISE A BILLIONAIRE

Having walked the ramp since she was a teenager, Maye Musk, 78, mother of tech tycoon Elon, is uniquely good at captivating an audience. At the India Today conclave, she waxed lyrical on the glamour of modelling, the satisfaction of being a nutritionist and the selflessness of parenthood.

Most recently the author of a memoir-cum-self-help book, *A Woman Makes a Plan*, she talked about how her son's sudden emergence in the limelight a decade ago shook her and her dietary practice, forcing her to recalibrate her goals. She said, "For 40 years, I saw patients every day, five days a week. That was my job and I loved it. I modelled part-time. And then I became Elon's mom... I said, I've got to stop my practice. I started teaching public health and then modelling took over. You don't expect that in your late 60s."

She spoke about navigating divorce, professional setbacks and repeated international migration with constant vigilance. "Only looking back do I say that I went through some horrible stages. I made a plan and changed it and started all over again. And I did that in nine cities and three countries. It's a struggle every time to change anything, and then you get to like it because you've left behind what you didn't like," she said.

The conversation also focused on happiness, family and independence. Musk's greatest joys, she says, have come from family and meaningful work, adding that raising her children was a defining part of her life and remains her proudest achievement. "The most fun I get is when I'm with my children and my grandchildren," she said. Ultimately, growing old doesn't have to mean growing up. Says Musk, "Age is great because you're alive." ■